4 LOSS OF INDEPENDENCE

And on that wave
we will all have to navigate,
all who are nourished
by the fruits of the Earth. (II, 14)

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN NOTHING HAPPENS?

It only takes a few micrograms of LSD to expand our experience of time onto an epic and magical scale.[35] "How long is forever?" asks Alice. "Sometimes, just one second," replies the White Rabbit. There are dreams lasting an instant in which everything seems frozen for an eternity.[36] Time is elastic in our personal experience of it. Hours fly by like minutes, and minutes are oppressively slow, as if they were centuries. On the one hand, time is structured by the liturgical calendar: Easter follows Lent, and Lent follows Christmas; Ramadan opens with Hilal and closes with Eid al-Fitr. On the other, every mystical experience, such as the sacred moment in which the host is consecrated, throws the faithful outside of time, putting them in touch with eternity. Before Einstein told us that it wasn't true, how the devil did we get it into our heads that time passes everywhere at the same speed? It was certainly not our direct *experience* of the passage of time that gave us the idea that time elapses at the same rate, always and everywhere. So where did we get it from?

For centuries, we have *divided* time into days. The word "time" derives from an Indo-European root—*di* or *dai*—meaning "to divide." For centuries, we have divided the days into hours.[37] But for most of those centuries, however, hours were longer in the summer and shorter in the winter, because the twelve hours divided the time between dawn and sunset: the first hour was dawn, and the twelfth was sunset, regardless of the season, as we read in the parable of the winegrower in the Gospel according to Matthew.[38] Since, as we say nowadays, during summer "more time" passes between dawn and sunset